

Prompting as Spec-Writing, and Attribution

THE IDEA IN ONE LINE

You are briefing a very fast, very literal colleague who has never met you.

THE FIVE PARTS

PART	ASK YOURSELF	EXAMPLE FRAGMENT
Context	Who is this for? What project?	I'm drafting a RAND research brief for a congressional staffer audience.
Task	One verb, one object	Summarize the methodological limitations of this study.
Constraints	Length, sources, tone, exclusions	Under 300 words. Only limitations the authors themselves acknowledge. No recommendations.
Examples	What does good look like?	Here is a paragraph in the house style: [paste].
Output shape	Table? Memo? Bullets?	Three-column table: limitation, page cite, severity.

QUICK WINS

- Say who the reader is. It changes vocabulary, length, and what gets left out.
- Give the model permission to say "not in the document." Otherwise it will invent.
- Ask for the output shape you will paste into your own work. Reformatting is wasted time.

- If you'd need to give a human an example, give the model one.

ATTRIBUTION AND DISCLOSURE

RAND's AI-use policy governs what you may do, and we read it together in Session 1. Know: what must be disclosed, where, and to whom; what's prohibited; what data can't go into which tools. If it's unclear, ask before you're asked. The words under your name are yours.

PITFALLS

- Compound asks ("summarize, critique, and rewrite") get mediocre results on all three. Split them.
- "Be concise" without a number means nothing. Say 200 words.
- Politeness costs nothing but adds nothing. Clarity is the courtesy.

GO DEEPER

- The RAND AI-use policy, as read in Session 1.
- Anthropic prompt engineering guide: docs.claude.com/en/docs/build-with-claude/prompt-engineering/overview
- OpenAI prompt engineering guide: platform.openai.com/docs/guides/prompt-engineering
- Ethan Mollick, *One Useful Thing* (practical, non-engineer): oneusefulthing.org